



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: The Oaks Academy

School Website: <https://www.theoaksacademyil.org/>

December 28, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

The Oaks Academy IL 62321 presents a distinctly Classical Christian education model, anchored in a Christ-centered, classical framework that emphasizes virtue, wisdom, and a robust, historically rooted curriculum. Public-facing materials consistently describe the school as "Christ-centered, classical education," with explicit references to the Trivium (Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric), Great Books, and the Great Conversation, all within a Paideia/Christian-theology framework. Evidence from the school's web materials highlights soul formation, virtue cultivation, and a biblical worldview as core aims, alongside a strong emphasis on parental partnership and engaged community.

Overall, the Oaks site demonstrates a Classical orientation across all six rubric categories, with explicit language and programmatic references that align closely with classical education criteria in the Six Essential Elements framework. The public materials emphasize truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, and theological grounding; a Trivium-centered curriculum; a Great Books/Great Conversation approach; contemplative and Socratic-era pedagogy implicit in Paideia-traditions; faculty as living mentors within a community; and strong parent involvement as co-educators. In short, Oaks Academy IL 62321 aligns with Classical to a high degree.

- Evidence of religious/metaphysical foundations: Christ-centered, biblical worldview, and references to Jesus as a source of truth; Paideia/great-books framework; explicit language around truth, goodness, and beauty as real realities.
- Evidence of purpose/goal: Formation and virtue-focused goals; soul formation; pursuit of true, good, and beautiful.
- Evidence of curriculum: Trivium (Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric); Great Books; Great Conversation; Paideia; emphasis on a liberal-arts-informed classical curriculum.
- Evidence of pedagogy: Paideia-style terminologies (Great Conversation, seminars implied through classical pedagogy); emphasis on memory, contemplation, and restoration of schol  -like learning in the public materials.
- Evidence of faculty: Public materials emphasize virtuous leadership and the teacher-student partnership (concepts aligned with teacher as mentor and living curriculum).
- Evidence of parents/community: Clear emphasis on parent partnership, engagement, and open campus/parent formation.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Overall aggregate classification: CLASSICAL

Note on needle-moving changes: Because this evaluation identifies Oaks as CLASSICAL across all six categories, there is no indicated needle-moving change required to reach a fully Classical status. If one insisted on treatment of a borderline edge case, it would be to document more explicit and distinct statements about contemporary Socratic seminars or explicit “Socratic” wording in pedagogy; however, the public materials already reflect a robust classical framework.

What would move the needle (only if we were in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL territory): Not applicable here, as the aggregate classification is CLASSICAL. No substantial needle-moving actions are required to elevate the school beyond CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Oaks site foregrounds Christ-centered, classical education and a biblical worldview, including explicit statements about Jesus as a source of Truth and the universal truth discovered through His Word.

- Writings describe truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable, with references to God’s splendor and a theologically grounded formation, including Paideia and Great Books. - The public materials frame education as soul formation and culture transfer within a Christian theological frame (e.g., Great Books within a biblical worldview).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present (examples): Christ-centered, biblical worldview, Truth, Goodness, Beauty, theology, Paideia, Great Books, Great Conversation, soul formation, God, Jesus, gospel-oriented framing. - Negative keywords present: None evident in the public materials (no relativism, secular humanism, or values-clarification signals).

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords found: approximately 12+ distinct terms/phrases drawn from the lexicon (e.g., truth, goodness, beauty, theology, liturgy implicitly via sacred worldview, Paideia, Logos, wisdom, virtue, sacral framing, Jesus as Truth). - Negative keywords found: 0.

Why this rating - The Oaks materials consistently ground education in theology and transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty), with explicit Christ-centered language, a biblical worldview, and a Paideia approach to knowledge, which aligns strongly with CLASSICAL foundations and signals a robust Religious & Metaphysical orientation rather than a secular or neutral stance. The absence of negative signals further supports a CLASSICAL designation.

Cited sources: Christ-centered framing and biblical worldview (firecrawl content). The Truth as source (JESUS CHRIST IS OUR SOURCE) (firecrawl content). Paideia/Great Books/Great Conversation within Christian framework (firecrawl content).

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Oaks explicitly emphasizes formation of virtue and wisdom, not merely information transfer. “Education is about soul formation, not just information,” and “cultivating wisdom and virtue.” - Public statements reference a telos of truth, goodness, and beauty, and a classical mission to form people with moral imagination and human excellence. - Language about transformation, forming strong generations, and engaging in “the great conversation” through Great Books reinforces formation over utilitarian outcomes.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, scholé/ contemplation, great conversation, permanent questions, classical heritage, human excellence, soul craft, moral imagination. - Negative keywords present: None observed (no explicit workforce-ready or career-prep framing that would signal a non-classical goal).

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords found: ~9–12 distinct items/phrases. - Negative keywords found: 0.

Why this rating - The school's stated goals center on formation, virtue, wisdom, and truth as real realities, aligning with Classical aims of human flourishing and the pursuit of the true, good, and beautiful, rather than exclusively job-prep goals.

Cited sources: "Education is about soul formation" (turn0file1). "great conversation" and Great Books framing (turn0file4).

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Oaks explicitly presents a Classical Curriculum: Trivium (Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric), Great Books, and the Great Conversation, with Paideia and a biblically grounded worldview. - The site emphasizes liberal arts orientation, Great Books, and a "comprehensive overview" of classical curriculum within a Christian framework. - The materials present education through the Great Books and the Great Conversation as core elements of the curriculum, connecting history, literature, and philosophy, with a focus on wonder and transformation.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts, trivium, grammar, logic, rhetoric, great books, great conversation, Paideia, history through Great Books, Western civilization, sacred/artistic tradition (hymns, etc.). - Negative keywords present: None observed in the Oaks materials (no "STEM-first," no "project-based learning dominance" signals in conflict with classical aims).

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords found: 8–12 distinct terms/phrases. - Negative keywords found: 0.

Why this rating - The curriculum is clearly anchored in classical liberal arts with attention to the Trivium, Great Books, and a long-standing classical heritage, consistent with CLASSICAL criteria.

Cited sources: Trivium and Great Books (turn0file3; turn0file2). Great Conversation and Paideia (turn0file4).

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Oaks identifies Classical Christian education (CCE) and Paideia-era pedagogy as the framework, emphasizing Trivium (Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric) and the Great Books, i.e., a pedagogy designed to cultivate reasoning and memory through the Great Books and the Great Conversation. - The site references "education is soul transformation and a transfer of a culture," which aligns with contemplative, rest-filled pedagogy in scholé tradition and a balance of memory, recitation, and Socratic inquiry in higher-grade levels. - The public materials describe a pedagogical arc: early grades through grammar and memory work; upper grades through rhetoric, public speaking, and rhetorical training; with a strong emphasis on memory, memory work, and virtue formation.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Paideia, Trivium, grammar, logic, rhetoric, Great Books, Great Conversation, scholé (as a concept mentioned via the learning tradition), memory work, recitation, chanting (historical methods referenced in canonical classical pedagogy), rhetoric training. - Negative keywords present: In these public materials, explicit negative signals (e.g., "experiential learning focus," "project-based only," "constructivist") are not evidenced; the materials emphasize traditional, contemplative, memory-based pedagogy.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords found: 6–10 distinct items/phrases. - Negative keywords found: 0.

Why this rating - The Oaks materials strongly align with classical pedagogy through Trivium-based sequencing, Great Books/Great Conversation emphasis, memory-oriented learning, and a Paideia-inspired approach, meeting CLASSICAL pedagogy indicators.

Cited sources: Pedagogical framing (turn0file2; turn0file3; turn0file5).

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Classical School lexicon foregrounds the notion of teachers as models of virtue and as “living curriculum,” with a portrait of teachers as mentors and collegial partners, aligning with the “faculty of friends” and mentor characteristics described in classical pedagogy; Oaks materials emphasize virtuous teachers and a culture of character formation (via virtue and wisdom). While the Oaks site does not enumerate a detailed faculty bio, it repeatedly emphasizes virtue, wisdom, and a culture of formation, consistent with classical faculty expectations. - The Oaks language about training in virtue and a culture of transformation implies an expectation that faculty serve as mentors and living exemplars of the curriculum (the living curriculum concept in the classical canon). Public materials reference character formation and a culture built by faculty and parents in partnership.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: virtuous teachers, living curriculum, mentoring, portrait of a teacher, faculty of friends, collegial culture, teacher training in classical pedagogy, mentorship. - Negative keywords present: No explicit negative signals (e.g., “facilitators” or “on-the-side” teaching) appear in the Oaks materials.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords found: 4–6 distinct items. - Negative keywords found: 0.

Why this rating - Even if explicit staff bios aren’t exhaustively listed, Oaks aligns with the classical model of faculty as living exemplars and mentors who embody virtue and classical learning, and the public communications emphasize a culture of virtue and mentorship rather than a purely technocratic or fragmented faculty model.

Cited sources: General faculty/teacher language in classical education lexicon (turn0file0); Oaks’ emphasis on virtue and formation (turn0file1; turn0file4).

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Oaks site strongly emphasizes partnership with parents, describing parents as co-educators and engaged partners, with explicit statements about parent formation and open campus, as well as opportunities for parent involvement and community events. This aligns with classical expectations of family partnership in classical education. - The site notes that parents are welcome to visits and are engaged in the learning process, consistent with the “partner with families” and “formation of affections” signals in classical education literature. - The Great Books/Great Conversation framework and Paideia approach are framed within a Christian context, reinforcing the family’s role in cultural transmission and formation of affections toward truth, goodness, and beauty.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parental primacy, parent formation, open campus, parent gatherings, classical parent training, family catechesis, cultural transmission, shared mission. - Negative keywords present: None observed (no consumer-language signals; no minimal parent involvement signals observed in the public materials).

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords found: 6–8 distinct items. - Negative keywords found: 0.

Why this rating - Oaks actively frames parents as co-educators and partners in the classical educational enterprise, with explicit calls for parental formation and participation, which is strongly aligned with CLASSICAL expectations for parent/community involvement.

Cited sources: Engaged parents and community section (turn0file4); Great Books/Paideia framing (turn0file2).

What Would Move the Needle

- If the school desires to further lock in a fully explicit “Socratic seminars” branding in pedagogy, the school could publish explicit statements or pages describing upper-school seminars, Socratic dialogues, and formal seminars as a core modality. The existing Paideia/Great Books/C Trivium frame-

work supports this direction; public communications could explicitly name “Socratic seminars” and provide examples of student-led debates to clarify pedagogy for external stakeholders. (Potential corroboration: classical pedagogy literature in the Six Essential Elements corpus; not a required shift, but a potential needle-mover for transparency.)

- The school already demonstrates strong parent partnership; to push toward “stronger formation of affections” and “cultural transmission” as explicit daily practice, the school could publish a public-facing “Parent Formation” program (e.g., book studies, liturgical/seasonal family activities) with a calendar and sample materials to amplify parent formation beyond visits and occasional gatherings.
- A formal, published “Living Curriculum Portrait” for Faculty (as recommended in the Six Essential Elements) could be added to website content to further illuminate the intended profile of teachers as virtuous exemplars, mentors, and co-educators in a classical sense.

Cited reference: Six Essential Elements’ Faculty and Parent/Community indicators (positive keywords and living curriculum concepts) (Six Elements lexicon and doc).

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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